

UNIT 4 · LESSON 1

What Is Grace Culture?

45–50 min · March Week 2 · Standard

OBJECTIVE	Students articulate the difference between grace culture and performance culture and identify which currently dominates their immediate community.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness (primary) · Relationship Skills (supporting)
DURATION	45–50 min · March Week 2 · Standard
KEY VOCABULARY	grace culture · performance culture · default assumption · goodwill · repair · psychological safety · contagion
OPENING REVIEW	'Unit 3 ended with the Grace Challenge. Today Unit 4 begins. The question shifts: from what do I practice individually to what do I build collectively. What does a community look like when grace is the default?'

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES 9–10 · EARLY HIGH SCHOOL

Goal 3 — Responsible Decision-Making

3A.4a Demonstrate personal responsibility in making ethical decisions.

Goal 2 — Social Awareness & Interpersonal Skills

2C.4b Evaluate one's contribution in groups as a member and leader.

Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).

ANCHOR CHART

GRACE CULTURE DEFAULT
ASSUMPTION: GOOD FAITH
REPAIR IS EXPECTED, NOT
EXCEPTIONAL
ACCOUNTABILITY IS
RESTORATIVE MISTAKES
GENERATE LEARNING
WHOLE PEOPLE — NOT
JUST PERFORMANCES

PERFORMANCE CULTURE
DEFAULT ASSUMPTION:
EVALUATION MISTAKES
GENERATE PUNISHMENT
ACCOUNTABILITY IS
PUNITIVE IMAGE OVER
SUBSTANCE PARTS OF
PEOPLE — THE USEFUL
PARTS ONLY

OPENING RITUAL

60–90 seconds 'Both feet on the floor. One breath slower than usual.' [Pause 10 seconds.] 'Unit 4 is the final unit of Book 4. It asks one question: what kind of room does the person you are becoming create? Today: the difference between a culture of grace and a culture of performance.' [Post: 'What kind of room does the person you are becoming create around them?']

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During Step 3, a student who names a home or family environment as the room they want to build differently — with visible weight and present-tense specificity.

MAY SIGNAL This student is carrying significant family context into Unit 4. Building grace culture in a genuinely unsafe family environment is not a Tier 1 classroom activity.

ACTION After class: 'The room you named — I want to make sure you have support in thinking about what grace culture looks like in that particular context. Can we talk about it?' Involve counselor if safety concerns are present. |

SCENARIO CARDS · FACILITATION NOTES

B4-22A and B4-22B B4-22A (NIKA'S CLASSROOM): Whole-class. Key: 'What performance culture norm is Nika disrupting — and what does she replace it with? Design five specific norms for a grace culture version of her classroom.' B4-22B (THE TEAM): Pairs. Key: 'The team's performance culture produces results at the cost of belonging. What would a grace culture version look like without sacrificing the standards?'

GRADE-BAND DIFFERENTIATION

GRADES 9 · 10	GRADES 11 · 12
Grades 9–10: Keep grace culture concrete and community-specific. The 'one room' exercise is the anchor — name a specific room, name a specific practice.	Grades 11–12: Connect to institutional frame — 'The college, workplace, or community you enter in the next year will have a culture. You will contribute to it from day one.' Connects to B5-U4-L1 and B5-U4-L6.

EXIT TICKET

"The difference between grace culture and performance culture is _____. The room I most want to build differently is _____. The one grace practice I could sustain in that room is _____." Journal — private. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Make the research on psychological safety concrete and credible — this is not feel-good curriculum. Grace culture is associated with measurably better outcomes. Students skeptical of grace as a serious alternative need the research. Amy Edmondson's work is your anchor — know it with specificity.

FAMILY CONNECTION · CONVERSATION STARTER

L1 Today students began Unit 4 — Community and Legacy. They examined the difference between performance culture (image management is primary, mistakes are terminal) and grace culture (goodwill is the default, repair is expected, mistakes are recoverable). Conversation-starter: 'What is one norm in our family — or a community you're part of — that you wish were different? What would the grace culture version look like?'

► DIRECT INSTRUCTION

Scripted teaching sequence · Steps 1 — 3 · read aloud or in your own words

01 PERFORMANCE CULTURE — WHAT IT COSTS**8 MIN**

Post the anchor chart. 'Most of you have spent three years in a high school performance culture — the curated identity (Unit 1), the perfectionist freeze (Unit 2), the conflict patterns that prioritize image over relationship (Unit 3). All of that is performance culture at the interpersonal level.' Ask: 'Describe the performance culture of one community you belong to right now — one specific norm that tells you image matters more than reality.' Name student responses on the board.

02 GRACE CULTURE — WHAT IT REQUIRES**10 MIN**

Write: GRACE CULTURE = goodwill as default + repair as expected + mistakes as recoverable. 'Amy Edmondson's research on psychological safety at Harvard shows that teams with high psychological safety are more creative, more productive, and more willing to take the risks that produce genuine innovation. Grace culture is not soft. It is what high-performance communities actually run on.' Pairs: 'Describe one grace culture you have been part of — at any scale. What made it feel different?'

03 GRACE IS CONTAGIOUS — THE ONE-PERSON SHIFT

7 MIN

'The research on social contagion shows that one person who consistently operates from a different set of norms can shift a community's culture over time.' [Pause.] 'The Grace Challenge you did in Unit 3 was personal. What happens if you don't stop?' Students write: 'One specific room I want to build differently is _____. The one grace practice I could sustain in that room is _____.'

SCENARIO CARDS

Print and laminate before unit. Two cards per lesson.

B 4 - 2 2 A THE ANONYMOUS ACT

THE SITUATION

Every year before graduation, one senior anonymously pays the unpaid lunch balance for the entire elementary school across the street. Nobody knows who it is. The tradition has continued for seven years. The person doing it gets nothing — no recognition, no thanks, no social credit. 'The whole point,' a former student said, 'is that it's not about you. It's about them. When you are the only one who knows, you find out who you actually are.'

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

What makes this act different from public generosity — and why does the anonymity matter? 'When you are the only one who knows, you find out who you actually are.' What does this mean? Acts of grace that cost the giver something are sometimes described as more genuine than those that don't. Do you agree — and why or why not? Design an anonymous act you could execute this week. What is its Grace Gap — the space in your environment where grace is absent?

ANONYMOUS GRACE *An act of grace becomes most revealing when it is anonymous — when no social credit is available. What you choose to do when no one is watching tells you more about your actual values than any stated commitment. Anonymous generosity is not superior to named generosity. But it is a particular test of character: it requires that the motivation be genuinely other-focused, not image-focused.*

B 4 - 2 2 B THE ANONYMOUS ACT

THE SITUATION

Nia noticed that one student in her class always had to borrow supplies and always seemed slightly embarrassed by it. She started keeping an extra set of pens and pencils in her bag that she left on the corner of her desk without comment. The student took them, always, without making eye contact. Nia never mentioned it to anyone. She didn't think of it as an act of grace. She thought of it as just noticing.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Nia didn't think of what she was doing as grace — she thought of it as 'just noticing.' What is the relationship between noticing and grace? Nia preserved the other student's dignity by not drawing attention. What does that cost — and why does it matter? Small, consistent acts of grace are described in research as more impactful than occasional large ones. What does Nia's practice suggest about this? What is a Grace Gap in your immediate environment that you could step into the way Nia stepped into hers?

NOTICING AS GRACE *Grace often begins with attention — the willingness to see what others overlook. Nia's act required no grand gesture, no public announcement, and no acknowledgment. It required only that she notice something real about another person's experience and respond to it with quiet consistency. This is what grace looks like in practice, most of the time: small, unannounced, and directed toward dignity.*

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · BOOK 4 · THE FAÇADE (9–10)

What Grace Is — and Is Not

Unit 4

GRACE

GRACE — THE ACTIVE EXTENSION

- Goodwill extended deliberately beyond what was earned
- Available at any time
- Does not require reciprocity
- Changes the room

GRACE IS NOT

- Passivity or weakness
- Ignoring harm
- Required in every situation
- Identical to niceness
- Unconditional approval

Grace changes the room. It is chosen strength, not niceness.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · BOOK 4 · THE FAÇADE (9–10)

Grace Culture vs. Performance Culture

Unit 4

GRACE

GRACE CULTURE

- Default assumption: good faith
- Repair is expected, not exceptional
- Accountability is restorative
- Mistakes generate learning
- Whole people — not just performances

PERFORMANCE CULTURE

- Default assumption: evaluation
- Mistakes generate punishment
- Accountability is punitive
- Image over substance
- Parts of people — the useful parts

One culture sees whole people. The other sees only the useful parts.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

This is a free preview.

Sample Lesson · Book 4 · The Façade (9–10)

The complete, classroom-ready curriculum — with anchor charts, worksheets, Illinois SEL alignment, and scripted Direct Instruction — is part of the Architecture of Grace district library. Educators can license the full set; families can find materials in the family store.

architectureofgrace.org